man?’ They looked blank, but when he explained that I had participated in the 1960 Rome Olympics, they exclaimed in excitement: ‘Oh, the saint!’ and asked for my autograph. During the Games, whenever I would appear from the tunnel that led into the stadium, the spectators would look at my long hair and beard, and cheer wildly, calling me a guru, a mendicant, a saint. It was that image that had remained in their minds for all these years.

I have always had a very close association with the Nehru– Gandhi family. Panditji loved sports and it was because of his influence that Delhi hosted the 1951 Asian Games. His daughter, Indira, would always joke with me about her running days when she was in school in Switzerland, and how she would always come first in the races. In 1982, at the Veterans’ Athletic Meet, she came up to the starting line, hitched up her sari and prepared to join the race. Her security guards were shocked, and pleaded with me to escort her back to the seating enclosure. Such are my warm memories of the Gandhi family.

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In the thirty years that I worked in the sports department, first as deputy director of sports, and then director of sports and education, I initiated several projects to promote and improve the quality of sports in the state. Among them was the opening of about thirty or forty sports wings attached to schools and colleges in various districts. The objective was to search for talented young players at the village and district levels and encourage them to take up sports as a career.

We sent messages to the principals of all educational institutions asking them to identify young boys and girls who showed promise in the field of sports, be it hockey, football, volleyball, athletics and more. Officials from our department would visit the schools and check what facilities they offered, including playgrounds, gymnasiums, hockey fields and athletic tracks. The next step was to hold trials and select the best, who were then placed in specially-created sports wings, where the government provided them with free tuition, hostel facilities, food, training and equipment like tracksuits and sports kits. We set up tough practice schedules and hired qualified coaches who could supervise and monitor their progress. In this way, the budding sportspersons would receive training in sports, and at the same time, continue their education.